CONTINENTAL DRIFT

BOOKS

Six interconnected and subtly ironic short stories by Buku Sarkar about life and its discontents, spanning two continents



Anjali Ray, the protagonist of the title-story, is a London-based author and life-style guru. She arrives in New York to attend the launch of her new book, *This Good Home*. Alas, her assistant Jenny is a low-energy flea and her editor, Sophie, is merely a well-tailored version of the same species.

Anjali, however, is a Calcutta-born alpha-tigress. She powers through the evening's near-disasters with steely aplomb, even as memories resurface of a doomed romance, in college days, with a lanky, drug-dealing bartender called Shane. We groan at Jenny's incompetence and the ghastly décor of the evening's venue alongside the grotty particulars of that long-dead affair. The distant close-shave with disaster dovetails neatly with the events of the launch. Ultimately, of course, wealth and privilege save the princess.

The skill with which the author delivers this double-headed narrative is impressive. By contrast, the other five pieces in this slender volume feel a bit like filler-foam. Two are told through the gaze of an adoring but less-privileged female friend of Anjali's called Anita. In 'The Visit', she's a young mother in a dead-end marriage with a dull man. She almost has an interesting adventure alone in New York only to have it deflate into nothingness. In 'The Conversation', she's set up a longed-for dinner date with her glamorous, globe-trotting friend. Predictably, the only meal on offer is late arrival and mediocre wine with bitter tears on the side.

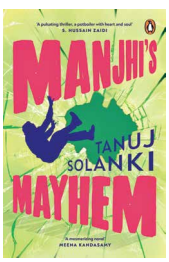
The skill with which author **Buku Sarkar** delivers a double-headed narrative is impressive

The two stories of childhood, written in the unnamed first person, have interesting fangs. In 'Afternoons', there's an encounter of the scary-sexy kind. In 'Auntie B' there's a class struggle between two little girls, fought with weapons of Coke versus Thums Up. Perhaps it takes guts to write directly about the snarky underside of growing up super-rich. But the lack of external perspective numbs any desire to know more. We can't possibly like the narrator because of her corrosive honesty, while the needy relatives remind us of all the times we were rude to our own.

'Lily and Reece' is a stark and pitiless visit to Shane's World. Anjali is seen

Subaltern Suspense

A good noir novel is more than mere entertainment. Tanuj Solanki's latest certainly fits the bill



MANJHI'S MAYHEM
by Tanuj Solanki
PENGUIN INDIA
₹399; 216 pages

Good Indian noir is an infrequent occurrence, especially in the written medium. Good Indian noir that also has insightful things to say about the systemic injustices of Indian society is rarer still. Tanuj Solanki's new novel, *Manjhi's Mayhem* (2022), featuring a rough-around-the-edges Dalit hero (the promotional literature calls him an 'anti-hero', which isn't really accurate) called Sewaram Manjhi, is a member of this small club.

Manjhi works as a security guard at a Mumbai café frequented by the well-heeled. At the restaurant across the road, a beautiful hostess named Santosh runs into a spot of bother, only for the muscular Manjhi to thrash the problems out of sight. From that point begins the 'mayhem': Manjhi becomes embroiled in a heist initiated by Santosh and her sister, and there are crooked bankers and mob bosses in the mix. Nobody's motivations are what they seem, and Manjhi must excavate the truth with his fists (but also his mind).

Solanki is good at taking a basic action set-piece—like Manjhi threatening a corrupt banker called Patil in front of his wife and teenaged daughter—and extracting incredible mileage from it. The wife doesn't know that Patil was 'gifted' a mistress (Santosh's sister Mithilesh) as payment for his less-than-legal banking services (when she finds out, she eggs on Manjhi, asking him to beat up her husband more).

She does, however, know banking quite well; better than her husband, in fact, and we're told that Patil forced her wife to quit banking because of... her work outfits. This is a wonderful detail, as is the fact that it's Mrs Patil who explains to Manjhi how the banking system works (he wants to know how Patil's 'scam' works), even as the lord of the manor cowers in the background.

Then there's Manjhi's fury at realising that poor farmers pay a higher